

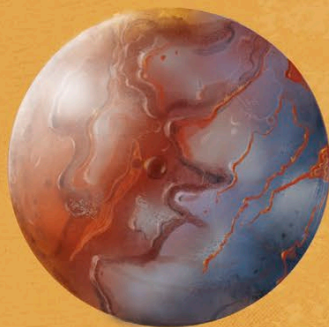
Life *on* Earth

Living things have dwelt on our planet for at least 3.5 billion years. The first life was nothing more than slimy scum made from single-celled microbes. But from these simple beginnings—and over countless generations—the world became filled with animals and plants that swarmed the oceans and turned the land green with forests.

Life begins

A billion years after Earth formed, its bare rocky land and deep blue oceans would have appeared empty of life. But somewhere under the waves, single-celled organisms—bacteria—became the first life on Earth.

Water flooded across the Earth's surface, turning much of it blue.



Earth is formed

There was a time when the sun was surrounded by just swirling clouds of dust and rocks. Then these clumped together to form the solar system's planets, including Earth.

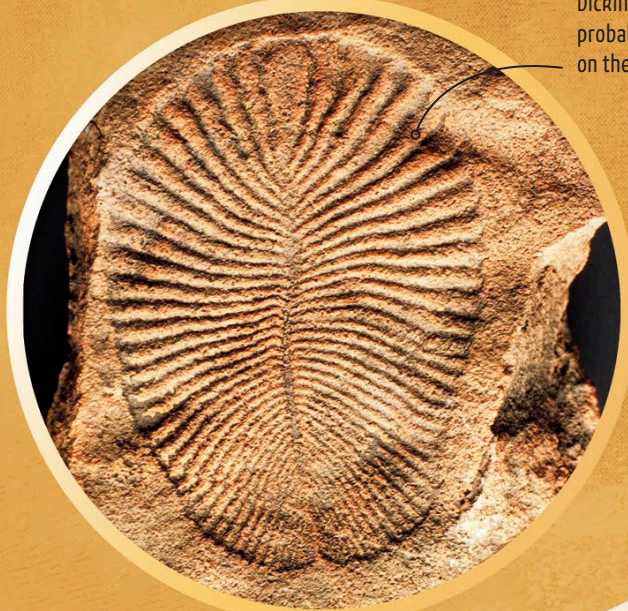
4.54
bya

bya = billion years ago
mya = million years ago

4
bya

First animals

Somewhere on the ocean floor, living things evolved to have larger bodies made up of billions of cells, so they grew much bigger than microbes. These were the very first animals—but they were unlike anything alive today.



The egg-shaped Dickinsonia probably crawled on the ocean floor.

600
mya

The Cambrian explosion

During a period of time called the Cambrian, conditions were just right for lots of different kinds of ocean animals to evolve. Many would have looked similar to creatures alive today, such as jellyfish, worms, and shrimps.

Many Cambrian animals, such as Marrella, had long creeping legs, sort of like a crab's.

